

Research In Psychology

Building a Research Identity Before You Graduate

Lecture by Ms. Rajitha K., Consultant Psychologist, GEM Hospital, Thrissur

Quick Brief Summary

Ms. Rajitha K. explains that research in psychology is not merely statistics, but a structured curiosity that helps improve human life. She inspires students to conduct interdisciplinary research within the Indian cultural context and to cultivate an interest in research during their undergraduate studies.

Detailed Summary

Introduction

The lecture 'Research In Psychology - Building a Research Identity Before You Graduate,' delivered by Ms. Rajitha K., a Consultant Psychologist at GEM Hospital, Thrissur, focused on transforming the attitude of psychology students toward research. She argues that research is not merely about statistics or stress, but rather a form of 'structured curiosity.' The lecture emphasizes the necessity for students to cultivate an interest in research during their undergraduate studies.

Main Theme: Research as Structured Curiosity

The speaker encourages students to set aside their fear and boredom regarding research and instead view it as an engaging subject. She clarifies that research is not just a means to obtain a PhD, but a scientific method to improve human life and contribute to society. True research is the process of bringing the curiosity found in children into a scientific framework.

Key Areas Explored

Research Potential in the Indian Context

The speaker highlights the importance of conducting research within India's unique cultural context rather than solely following Western theories. India's diverse cultures, languages, rural-urban differences, and family structures offer vast opportunities for research. She points out that studies tailored to the Indian context are particularly needed in areas such as geriatric care, mental health, and social change.

The Importance of Interdisciplinary Research

The speaker explains that psychology is not an isolated field but one that must work in conjunction with areas like medicine, AI, education, business, and law. Using examples, she illustrates that multidisciplinary research—collaborating with experts from various fields—is more effective in addressing topics such as the mental health of cancer patients, perinatal mental health, and digital addiction.

Research Methods and Practical Approaches

The speaker discussed the importance of descriptive studies, longitudinal studies, and qualitative approaches. There is significant potential for research in fields like perinatal mental health, caregiver burden, and cyberpsychology. She also reminded students of the necessity to validate and adapt Western scales to our culture rather than using them as they are.

KEY INSIGHTS: Guidelines for Research

- **Cultivate Curiosity:** Research questions originate from the curiosity found in children; therefore, do not hesitate to ask questions.
- **Literature Review:** Read existing studies and identify research gaps.
- **Collaboration:** Work in collaboration with other departments and experts.
- **Publication:** Participate in conferences, present abstracts, and write book chapters.

Conclusion

The speaker concludes by stating that research is like telling a story, which must contain a clear beginning and accurate information. The lecture ended with a call for students to use research as a tool to build their careers. This was followed by a Q&A session where the speaker addressed students' doubts and provided guidance on how those interested in research can connect with experts.

Highlights

Research is Structured Curiosity

Instead of viewing research merely as statistics or something boring, it should be seen as a process of scientifically organizing the curiosity inherent in children. Research becomes meaningful only when focusing on subjects of interest.

Research possibilities in the Indian context

Rather than relying solely on Western theories, there are great opportunities to conduct research based on India's cultural diversity, language, family systems, and rural-urban differences. Culturally relevant studies are currently being prioritized.

Interdisciplinary Approach

Psychology is a field that needs to work in conjunction with various sectors such as medicine, social work, AI, law, and environmental science. Multi-disciplinary research provides more beneficial results for society.

Ways for students to start research

One can begin their research journey at the undergraduate level itself through systematic literature reviews, presenting abstracts at conferences, and writing book chapters. Secondary research is an excellent starting point.